16

MERGERS, ACQUISITIONS AND THE 'EIGHT GODDESSES'

The BJP's Northeast Push

What does the ancient Hindu legend of Lord Krishna and how he eloped with Rukmini, when she was being married against her will to the Chedi King Shishupal, have to do with India's Northeast and BJP's expansion? Actually, quite a lot. At the 2018 Madhavpur Magh Mela near Gujarat's Porbandar port, Gujarat Chief Minister Vijay Rupani claimed that Rukmini was a princess from Arunachal Pradesh, and that the region had been a part of India since the Dwapar Yug of the Hindu epics. The BJP's Manipur chief minister, N. Biren Singh, also at the event, agreed: 'By marrying Rukmini, Krishna had bound the Northeast to Krishna … Lord Krishna made them [Northeastern states] part of India during his time.' Arunachal Chief Minister Pema Khandu, also of the BJP, who had specially flown in for the event, concurred: 'We watch in news channels today that some other country is claiming some part of Northeast. But nobody can change the history and the ancient history says that Arunachal was not a separate state but entire Northeast was one. For centuries, we have been with India, mainland India.'[1] In one quick leap, BJP chief ministers had connected the tribal cultures of the Northeast with the cosmology and lore of the Hindu epics.